

COMPETITIVE AUDIT · USED VEHICLE ACQUISITION

How the rest of the industry is buying cars from the public — and what we should learn from it.

A side-by-side look at the customer journey on every major sell-your-car website in May 2026 — Carvana, CarMax, Cars.com, CarGurus, AutoNation, KBB, Edmunds, Peddle, plus the dealer plug-ins (TradePending, AccuTrade, Roadster). What works, what doesn't, and what to put in front of our customers.

Prepared for: Used Car Manager

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Format: Internal review

Bottom line — five things to take away from this report

1. **The market expects a real, firm offer in 2 minutes — good for 7 days.**
Carvana set this standard and everyone else copied it. Customers walk if you give them a "range" or a "we'll call you back."
2. **Lead with the license plate, not the VIN.** Premium players (Carvana, CarMax, CarGurus, AutoNation, AccuTrade) all do this. VIN-first costs you customers who can't find the VIN on their phone in the parking lot.
3. **Two screens to a number.** Plate + mileage + a few yes/no condition questions, then the offer. Anything longer bleeds customers at every step.
4. **Don't ask for an email or phone before showing the number.** Every winning flow shows the offer first and collects contact info next to it. The losers gate it up front and watch their conversion rate drop.
5. **Stay on our own URL, in our own colors.** Customers don't trust a redirect off the dealership website to some third-party brand. The plug-in vendors (TradePending, AccuTrade) both market this as their #1 feature for a reason.

1 Who's in the market right now

The sell-your-car space splits into three groups. They look similar from the outside but each has a very different business model — which shapes how their customer flow is designed.

The big three buyers (they buy your customer's car directly)

Company	What they really are	Pressure they put on the dealer
Carvana	National online used-car retailer with their own buy desk	Sets the customer's expectation for "instant firm offer + 7-day hold"
CarMax	Bricks-and-mortar used-car superstore with online front door	Customer walks in with a CarMax offer in hand and demands you beat it
AutoNation	Largest franchise dealer group; runs a centralized buy program	Direct competitor for franchise rooftops in the same market

The marketplaces (they sell your customer's lead to multiple buyers)

Company	Model	Why customers go there
Cars.com Quick Offer	Customer enters details once, multiple dealers/auctioneers bid	"I'll see what everybody offers and pick the highest"
CarGurus IMCO	Same — picks the highest offer from a network of dealers	"Compare offers in 2 minutes" headline
KBB Instant Cash Offer	KBB generates the number; participating dealer redeems it	"KBB said it's worth \$X" — the trust anchor

The buy-everything tier (older / damaged / non-running cars)

Company	Model	Why this matters to us
Peddle	Buys 8,000+ cars/week; mostly older trade-ins	They're the price floor when a customer's car is too rough for retail

Company	Model	Why this matters to us
Wheelzy	Junk-car buyer with a phone-first flow	Same — they're the alternative when we say "we can't use it"
CarBrain	Damaged / non-running specialist	Same

The dealer plug-ins (what gets installed on a dealer website today)

Vendor	What it puts on the dealer's site	What the customer sees
TradePending	A trade-in widget that stays on the dealer URL	Value range "Your car is worth \$X – \$Y"
AccuTrade (Cox / Cars Commerce)	Plate-based instant offer tool, single page	Firm offer at VIN-level precision
Roadster (CDK)	Trade-in step embedded inside a full digital-retailing checkout	Firm offer as part of buying another car
Modal / Drive Motors	Full e-commerce; trade-in is one tile	Range or firm depending on dealer config
Gubagoo	Trade-in tied to live chat	Range, with a chat agent following up

2 Side-by-side: what each one asks the customer

Steps = how many distinct screens the customer sees before getting a dollar amount. Less is better.

Site	First field	Steps to a number	Offer shape	How long is the offer good for?
Carvana	Plate or VIN	~3	Firm	7 days

Site	First field	Steps to a number	Offer shape	How long is the offer good for?
CarMax	VIN or plate	2–3	"Starting point" until in-store	7 days
Cars.com Quick Offer	Plate	2	Range + dealer bids	Varies by dealer
CarGurus IMCO	Plate or VIN	~2	Firm (highest bid wins)	~7 days
AutoNation	VIN or plate	4–5	Firm "Certified Offer"	7 days or 500 miles
Peddle	Year/Make/Model dropdowns	~4	Firm instant offer	7 days
Wheelzy	Year/Make/Model	~3	Firm phone-forward	"Won't decrease"
CarBrain	VIN preferred	~2 (90 sec)	Firm	7 days
KBB Instant Cash Offer	Plate, VIN, or Y/M/M	5–6	Firm at participating dealer	7 days, pending inspection
Edmunds Appraisal	VIN, plate, or Y/M/M	3	Range (4 different values)	n/a — informational
TradePending (dealer plug-in)	Plate or VIN	2	Range	Local-market live
AccuTrade (dealer plug-in)	Plate or VIN	1	Firm VIN-level	Dealer-set
Vroom	Defunct — wound down January 2024			

Site	First field	Steps to a number	Offer shape	How long is the offer good for?
Shift	Defunct	— Chapter 11, October 2023		

3 What each player nailed — and what they blew

One thing each company is doing right that we should steal, and one thing they're doing wrong that we should avoid.

Carvana

WIN One brand promise — "real offer in 2 minutes, good for 7 days" — repeated everywhere. Their turquoise color reads modern and tech-forward, not used-car-lot.

LOSS Forces a "sell or trade?" choice up front, before showing any number. Customers don't know the answer yet — they just want to see what their car is worth.

CarMax

WIN Two-track design: instant online offer to grab the customer, free in-store firm offer to close them. It's the dual-track every franchise dealer should be running.

LOSS The online number is hedged as a "starting point" — which contradicts their own "instant offer" pitch. Customers feel like they're being baited.

Cars.com

WIN Multi-offer comparison ("private party vs. dealer vs. trade") sets honest expectations and educates the customer before they've talked to anybody.

LOSS Brand color palette (purples and grays) reads more like a software CMS than a car website. Doesn't match the customer's mental model of what a car-buying site looks like.

CarGurus (IMCO)

WIN "Compare multiple offers in under 2 minutes" — clear, time-boxed promise. Customers know exactly what they're getting and how long it'll take.

LOSS The dealer network has gaps in some states, so the promise quietly degrades — a customer in a smaller market may get fewer or no offers.

AutoNation

WIN "7 days or 500 miles" makes the offer sound operational and specific, not promotional. That's a phrase to copy.

LOSS 5 minutes and 4–5 screens to a number — the longest in the field. Every extra screen costs them customers.

Peddle

WIN Year/Make/Model dropdowns first (no plate friction for a 2002 Tahoe) — exactly right for the older / rougher tier they specialize in.

LOSS Dense text-heavy mobile form. Looks like 2018. Functional but cheap.

KBB Instant Cash Offer

WIN "Real offer for a specific amount, 7 days, redeem at a participating dealer" — the gold-standard script. Every word does work.

LOSS Form is long: color, engine, transmission, history, condition, contact — that's 6 sections of inputs before the customer sees a dollar amount.

Edmunds

WIN Shows three to four different values (trade-in, private party, dealer retail, certified pre-owned) so the customer learns what each one means.

LOSS The "range" hedge confuses customers who came expecting a single number. Carvana has trained the public to expect one.

TradePending (the dominant dealer plug-in)

WIN Stays on the dealer's URL — no redirect, no third-party brand on screen. Best dealer-trust alignment in the field.

LOSS Outputs a range, not a firm number. In a Carvana-trained world, this is the wrong answer — it makes the dealer look less professional than the national online buyers.

AccuTrade (Cox Automotive's answer)

WIN Single-page collapse: plate prefills mileage and history, and the customer sees a firm VIN-level number on one screen. As frictionless as it gets.

LOSS Requires a mature dealer ops setup behind the scenes — most rooftops can't pull it off without retooling their reconditioning math.

4 The patterns that consistently work — and the ones that consistently don't

After looking at all of the above, the same wins and losses show up over and over. This is the actionable list.

WHAT WORKS

- **Plate + ZIP as the first input.** Resolves to a VIN behind the scenes — saves the customer 4 dropdown screens.
- **A firm offer with a 7-day hold.** A range is the losing answer in 2026.
- **Two screens to a number.** Plate, mileage, a few yes/no condition questions, done.
- **A visible time anchor in the headline.** "2 minutes." "Instant." "90 seconds." Every winning page has one.
- **Show the offer before asking for email or phone.** Email field next to the offer, not before it.
- **Stay on the dealer's URL.** No redirect to a third-party brand.
- **Branching yes/no condition questions** (any accidents? does it run?) — easy for the customer to answer honestly.
- **Operational language, not promotional language.** "7 days or 500 miles" beats "great offer guaranteed!"

WHAT DOESN'T

- **Asking for an account or email before the number.** Kills conversion rate. Every top player avoids it.
- **"Excellent / Very Good / Good / Fair / Poor" condition sliders.** Customers always over-rate. Use yes/no questions instead.
- **Long Year/Make/Model dropdowns when a plate would work.** Looks junk-tier on a franchise dealer site.
- **Range output (\$X – \$Y).** Carvana taught the public to expect one number. A range looks like the dealer is hedging.
- **Black hero / dark mode on a mainstream brand.** Reads as buy-here-pay-here or scam. Light mode wins everywhere except true luxury.
- **Phone number above the fold** on a franchise dealer site — that's a Wheelzy junk-tier signal. Push it to header utility nav.
- **Forking "sell vs. trade" before showing any value.** Customer doesn't know yet — show the number, then offer the upsell.
- **FAQ accordions and testimonials above the fold.** Top players strip everything to a headline and a form card. Trust signals come below.

5 What colors and visual style read as trustworthy

The field clusters into four visual buckets. Each one sends a very specific message — and you don't always have a choice about which one your dealer logo lands in.

Bucket	Examples	What it reads as to a customer
Premium / institutional blue	Carvana, CarMax, CarGurus	Trustworthy. Bank-or-insurance-adjacent.
Approachable consumer	Cars.com, Edmunds	Friendly. Marketplace. Browse-y.
Premium minimalist	KBB modern refresh, AccuTrade	Clinical. B2B-credible. "Tool, not store."
Low-trust / loud	Wheelzy, junk-tier sites	Spammy. "We buy junk." Avoid.

Three palette options for our customer-facing landing page

All three are designed to work behind any dealer logo without clashing — they're "default safe" colors when the dealer hasn't picked their own.



Institutional Blue

Default safe pick — works behind almost any dealer logo

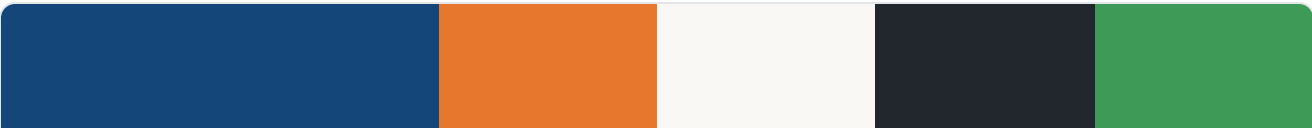
Primary	#0B3A6F
Accent	#1FB6C7
Surface	#F7F9FC
Ink	#0F1722
Success	#2BA86B



Premium Minimalist

Luxury / import dealers (BMW, Lexus, Infiniti, Audi)

Primary	#111418
Accent	#C9A24A
Surface	#FFFFFF
Ink	#1B1F25
Tint	#EDEEF1



Approachable Domestic

Mainstream / family rooftops (Ford, Chevy, Toyota, Honda)

Primary	#15467A
Accent	#E8772E
Surface	#FAF8F4
Ink	#22272E
Success	#3E9A57

Avoid: pure black backgrounds, pure red Call-To-Action buttons, neon green, and yellow text on white. All four correlate with the "low-trust / loud" cluster.

6 The recipe — what our customer should see

A concrete description of the customer's first 90 seconds on our landing page. Walk through this with marketing and we have a spec.

Above the fold (mobile, in source order)

1. **Dealer logo, top left.** No third-party co-branding. The customer should feel they're on the dealership's site.
2. **Headline:** *"Sell your car to [Dealer Name] — real offer in 2 minutes, good for 7 days."* The Carvana script, our store's name on it.
3. **A single form card:** license plate field, state field (auto-filled by location, editable), one small grey link that reads *"Don't have your plate? Use VIN or year/make/model."*
4. **One Call-To-Action button:** "Get my offer." Full-width on mobile. Primary color.
5. **One trust line** directly under the CTA: *"Backed by [Dealer Name] · Since [year] · [N] cars purchased this year."* Add Google review stars + count if we have them.

The flow after that

1. **Screen 1:** plate, state, mileage. (Plate resolves to a VIN behind the scenes — we already know the year/make/model/trim/options.)
2. **Screen 2:** three to five yes/no condition questions. Title status. Any accidents? Does it run? Major mechanical? Exterior condition (one pick from *three*, not five — "great / decent / rough").
3. **Screen 3:** the offer reveals, with a 7-day countdown badge. Email and phone fields appear next to the number, not before it. Customer can lock the offer in or schedule an appointment from this screen.

What we should NOT put above the fold

- The dealership phone number (push it to the header utility nav)
- A "How it works" 3-step graphic

- A stock photo of a car the customer doesn't own
- An inventory grid
- A floating chat bubble on top of the form
- A "Sell or trade?" choice (defer that until after the number)
- An FAQ accordion or a Spanish-language toggle
- A BBB logo (it correlates with junk-tier sellers)

7 Sources & methodology

Where the data in this report came from, so the manager can verify any claim.

The pages of carvana.com, carmax.com, cars.com, cargurus.com, kbb.com, edmunds.com, autonation.com and peddle.com all blocked our automated reader (HTTP 403). All UX claims about those flows are reconstructed from secondary writeups dated 2025–2026, vendor product pages, and recent industry coverage. To verify any specific claim in person, walk through the corresponding URL on a phone:

- carvana.com/sell-my-car
- carmax.com/sell-my-car
- cars.com/sell
- cargurus.com/sell-car
- autonation.com/sell-my-car
- peddle.com
- wheelzy.com/caroffer
- carbrain.com/sell-your-junk-car
- kbb.com/instant-cash-offer
- edmunds.com/appraisal
- tradepending.com
- carscommerce.inc/accutrade

Vroom and Shift are confirmed defunct as of 2024 — Vroom wound down its e-commerce in January 2024, Shift filed Chapter 11 in October 2023.

Internal competitive review. Compiled May 2026.

This document is a snapshot — competitor flows change frequently. Re-audit quarterly.